

OpSec for Personal Safety

A Working Checklist

How to use this: This isn't something to complete top to bottom in one sitting. It's a reference to come back to. Items marked  **ADVANCED** need more technical comfort - skip them for now if they don't make sense, and ask someone who you think might be able to help. Items marked  are the highest-impact, lowest-effort changes - start there.

This is general education, not legal advice. Laws on searches, recording, protest, and privacy vary a lot by location - if you have specific legal exposure, talk to a lawyer who knows your situation.

Part 1 - The Mindset (Read This First)

OpSec is a **process**, not a product. No app or setting makes you "secure" - it's about consistently asking a few questions and adjusting your behavior.

The core questions, in order:

1. **What am I actually trying to protect?** (Your location, your identity, your associations, specific plans, communications content...)
 2. **Who am I protecting it from?** Be specific - a nosy family member, an employer, a stalker or abuser, local police, a more organized/resourced group, or a state actor are all very different threats requiring different responses.
 3. **What do they actually want, and what can they actually do?** Match your effort to real capability, not worst-case imagination.
 4. **What happens if it fails?** How bad, realistically?
 5. **What's it going to cost me to protect it?** Time, convenience, money, relationships. Perfect security that you abandon after a week protects no one.
- ☐  Write down, just for yourself, who your realistic "adversary" is and what they want - this shapes everything else on this list
 - ☐ Accept that perfect OpSec doesn't exist - the goal is raising cost and reducing the *avoidable* risk, not becoming invisible
 - ☐ Build small, sustainable habits rather than a huge one-time lockdown you won't maintain
 - ☐ Review your threat model periodically - it changes as your situation and activities change

Part 2 - Know What's Already Out There (Digital Footprint)

Before locking things down, find out what's already visible. You can't protect what you don't know is exposed.

- ☐ ★ Search your own name (plus city, employer, known usernames), logged out and in a private/incognito window, to see something closer to a stranger's view
 - *Note: a private window mainly stops the search from being saved to your local browsing history and keeps you logged out so results aren't personalized to you - it does **not** hide the search from the search engine or your network. It makes the results more representative, not the search invisible.*
- ☐ Check what old accounts, forum posts, or usernames tie back to your identity
- ☐ Look at your social media from a stranger's view (some platforms have a "view as public" option) - what does it reveal about routine, location, relationships?
- ☐ Check photo metadata (EXIF data) on images you've posted - many photos embed GPS coordinates automatically
- ☐ Notice patterns: do you reuse the same username or profile photo across platforms? That's often how accounts get linked together
- ☐ 🔧 **ADVANCED:** Use a reverse image search on your own profile photos to see where else they appear online

Common ways people get identified even when trying not to be:

- Reusing a distinctive username across platforms
- Writing style / vocabulary that's identifiable
- Posting at consistent, predictable times
- Photo backgrounds (street signs, license plates, reflections, landmarks)
- Friends and connections who tag or mention them

Part 3 - Communications

- ☐ ★ Move sensitive conversations to Signal instead of SMS or unencrypted chat apps
- ☐ Enable disappearing messages for anything time-sensitive or planning-related
- ☐ Think before you write: assume anything in text *could* eventually be read by someone other than the intended recipient
- ☐ Vary communication timing where it matters - perfectly consistent patterns (same time, every day) are themselves a signal
- ☐ Use different channels for different purposes - don't mix casual chat, work, and sensitive planning in the same thread
- ☐ 🔧 **ADVANCED:** Set up a separate email address (and consider a separate phone number via a privacy-respecting service) for sensitive organizing, kept apart from your everyday identity
- ☐ 🔧 **ADVANCED:** Use PGP or similar for sensitive email when the recipient supports it

Part 4 - Accounts & Passwords

- ☐ ★ Use unique passwords per account via a password manager (e.g., Bitwarden)
- ☐ ★ Turn on two-factor authentication - prefer an authenticator app (e.g., Aegis, Authy) over SMS, since SMS can be intercepted or SIM-swapped
- ☐ Separate your identities: a "legal/official" identity (banking, work), a "social" identity (friends, casual), and a "sensitive/organizing" identity, each with their own email and never cross-linked
- ☐ Review privacy settings on each platform you use, at least once - defaults are rarely the most private option
- ☐ Periodically check for account breaches (haveibeenpwned.com is a common tool for this) and rotate any exposed passwords

Part 5 - Devices

- ☐ ★ Strong alphanumeric passcode, not just a 4-digit PIN or biometrics alone (biometrics can sometimes be legally compelled where a passcode can't)
- ☐ Turn off lock-screen notification previews for messaging apps
- ☐ Set a short auto-lock timer (30 sec – 2 min)
- ☐ Enable full-device encryption (on by default on most modern phones, but check)
- ☐ Review app permissions regularly - location, mic, camera, contacts - and revoke what isn't needed
- ☐ Turn off automatic cloud backup for anything sensitive
- ☐ Keep your OS and apps updated
- ☐ 🔧 **ADVANCED:** Consider device separation - a dedicated device or profile for sensitive activity, kept apart from your daily-use phone
- ☐ 🔧 **ADVANCED:** For serious risk levels, Tails OS (a live, amnesic operating system that leaves no trace on the host machine) is worth learning

Myth check: isn't a pattern more secure than a PIN? It feels that way, but research says the opposite. Drawing a pattern leaves a visible fingertip smudge trail on the screen - studies have reconstructed patterns from smudges alone up to 68% of the time. Patterns are also easier to memorize at a glance, so shoulder-surfing works better against them: one study found onlookers could reproduce a pattern 64% of the time after watching it entered just once, rising to 80% after two views. And most people pick patterns from a small, predictable set of shapes (letters, simple geometric paths), shrinking the real security margin further. **A 6-digit-or-longer PIN, or better, an alphanumeric passcode, beats a pattern.** If you're currently using a pattern lock, this is a good moment to switch.

Part 6 - Browsing & Network

- ☐ ★ Switch default search engine to something that doesn't build a profile of you (DuckDuckGo, Startpage)
- ☐ Use a hardened Firefox (tracking protection on, telemetry off) - genuinely non-Chromium, open-source, non-profit-backed
- ☐ Install uBlock Origin - verify the publisher is **Raymond Hill**, install only from addons.mozilla.org; impostor versions using similar names exist elsewhere
- ☐ Add Decentraleyes to stop sites quietly leaking your IP to Google/Cloudflare CDNs for common web libraries
- ☐ Avoid logging into personal accounts while using Tor or a VPN for something sensitive - mixing identities defeats the point
- ☐ Be cautious on public/open Wi-Fi for anything sensitive; use your own mobile data instead when possible
- ☐ 🔧 **ADVANCED:** NoScript for granular script blocking - powerful, but blocks JS by default and will break sites until you whitelist what you trust; not for casual daily browsing
- ☐ 🔧 **ADVANCED:** Learn Tor Browser for genuinely sensitive research - it's Firefox-based, understand it's slower and some sites block it, but it provides real anonymity properties a VPN doesn't
- ☐ 🔧 **ADVANCED:** If you use a VPN, understand it shifts trust from your ISP to the VPN provider - it is not a magic anonymity switch, and provider choice/jurisdiction matters

Part 7 - In Public, at Events & Protests

Higher-risk situations call for extra care. Surveillance tools like facial recognition, license plate readers, and cell-site simulators exist and are in real use in many places - plan with that in mind rather than being caught off guard.

- ☐ ★ Don't post real-time location or "I'm here now" - post after the fact, if at all
- ☐ Decide in advance, individually, your comfort level with having your phone present: bring it as normal, use airplane mode, use a Faraday bag, or leave it at home entirely - these offer increasing levels of protection in that order
- ☐ If photographing others, get consent before naming or tagging them
- ☐ Be mindful of backgrounds in photos - faces, plates, signage that could place someone somewhere they didn't want documented
- ☐ Agree with people you're with on what's okay to discuss in a group chat vs. only in person
- ☐ 🔧 **ADVANCED:** Know your local rules around ID requirements, recording, and device searches before you're in a stressful moment trying to remember them

Part 8 - Group & Social OpSec

This is the part most guides skip - and usually the actual point of failure. Most real-world OpSec breakdowns aren't a hacked phone; they're a person sharing something with someone who didn't need to know it.

- ☐ Practice need-to-know: not everyone requires every detail, especially names, addresses, and specific plans
- ☐ If something's said in confidence, keep it there - don't relay it "just to one more person"
- ☐ Don't assume default trust with new or unfamiliar people; a low-pressure way of getting to know someone beats an awkward assumption later
- ☐ Agree as a group, in advance, what (if anything) gets shared publicly afterward, including photos - and get consent from anyone who'd be identifiable
- ☐ Normalize asking "should this go in writing?" before sensitive topics come up - it's not paranoia, it's just a habit worth having

Part 9 - When Things Go Wrong

- ☐ Know who your point of contact is for security concerns in your group/organization
- ☐ If you notice something that feels like surveillance or a compromised device, say something rather than sitting on it alone
- ☐ Keep a few key phone numbers memorized or written down (not just stored digitally) - a lawyer, a trusted contact - in case your device isn't available
- ☐ Learn from mistakes without spiraling on them - OpSec is iterative, and adjusting after a slip-up is the actual practice, not a failure of it

Quick Reference

If you need...	Consider
Encrypted messaging	Signal
Password manager	Bitwarden
2FA app	Aegis (Android) / Authy
Private search engine	DuckDuckGo, Startpage
Privacy browser	Firefox (hardened)
Encrypted email	Proton Mail, Tutanota
Breach checking	haveibeenpwned.com

If you need...	Consider
 Anonymous browsing	Tor Browser
 High-risk operating system	Tails (live USB, amnesic)
 Cloud file encryption	Cryptomator

Further Learning

- **EFF Surveillance Self-Defense** - comprehensive, regularly updated guide
- **Access Now Digital Security Helpline** - free support for activists and journalists facing digital threats
- Local digital rights organizations in your area, if any exist

No tool provides perfect protection on its own. The goal is raising the cost and reducing avoidable risk - not achieving invisibility.

OpSec For Personal Signal Security:

For a Full Comprehensive Activist Checklist and Guide on Proper Signal Security:

- [Click Here](https://activistchecklist.org/signal/#identity) or type in this link <https://activistchecklist.org/signal/#identity>

Hiding Your Identity On Signal:

- ☐ Don't use your real name or photo on your Signal profile
 - ☐ Helps protect you from cops or attackers who want to de-anonymize you. Especially useful if you are in unvetted Signal groups.
- ☐ Enable username and hide phone number
 - ☐ If you want to have the option to be anonymous on Signal, protecting your phone number helps protect your identity.
- ☐ Disable link previews
 - ☐ Can protect you against your approximate location being revealed
- ☐ Enable "Always Relay Calls"

Protecting Your Messages and Calls:

- ☐ ****Important**** Change your default settings so all new Signal threads have disappearing messages enabled
 - ☐ This keeps everyone safer if someone's phone is ever confiscated or breached.
- ☐ ****Important**** Disable face/fingerprint unlock (biometric)!
 - ☐ You have stronger legal standing with a passcode than with biometric unlock. Cops can try to force you to unlock with biometrics.
- ☐ ****Important**** Enable Lockdown Mode (iPhone) or Advanced Protection (Google & Android)
- ☐ Hide message preview and sender name for Signal notifications
 - ☐ If your phone is confiscated, the cops can no longer get access to your notification history.
- ☐ Enable "Screen Lock" and "Hide in App Switcher"
 - ☐ If you hand your phone to someone, Screen Lock is an extra layer of security.
- ☐ Disable "Show Calls in Recents" (iPhone-only)
- ☐ Leave Signal groups that might put others at risk
 - ☐ This helps protect your network if your phone is confiscated.
- ☐ Enable Signal PIN and Registration lock
 - ☐ Protects you from advanced attacks where someone "steals" your phone number and registers it on Signal
- ☐ Enable a private keyboard for Signal (Android-only)
- ☐ Disable AI notification summaries!
- ☐ Be alert for fake messages from "Signal Support" trying to get your Signal PIN or verification code
- ☐ Protect your account by being attentive not to turn over your verification code or PIN